what would be otherwise. The Mighty alone can afford to be merciful and, therefore, where else can the prodigal son return but to the parental doors of the government.'

The parental doors of the BJP government were certainly thrown open to Savarkar; his behaviour towards the British rulers was airbrushed from official accounts of his life, a hagiographic biopic was released in 2001, and his portrait was even hung in Parliament's Central Hall, deliberately positioned to face that of Mahatma Gandhi.

During BJP rule at the head of a coalition government in Delhi, a purely BJP government, headed by a fiery and articulate ideologue, Chief Minister Narendra Modi, ruled Gujarat. It was on this government's watch that 1,000 to 2,000 people, mainly Muslims, were massacred in 2002, in a pogrom against that community that blighted the state's normally tranquil capital, Ahmedabad, and other places in Gandhi's homeland. The chief minister was accused of condoning the killings—or at the very least not taking prompt action to stop them—which ceased only after the Army was called in three days after they began. It was reported that Prime Minister Vajpayee wanted to dismiss him for his failure to prevent the massacre, but was dissuaded by the Hindutva hardliners in his administration.[61] (Senior BJP leader Venkaiah Naidu confirmed this story on the record as an example of his party's democratic decision-making—according to Naidu, Prime Minister Vajpayee wanted Modi to resign as Gujarat chief minister after the 2002 riots, but had to give in to the party's 'collective decision' against the idea.) Be that as it may, the Gujarati public rallied behind him; Modi was re-elected as chief minister of Gujarat in elections later that year, 2002, and returned to office again with ever-larger majorities in 2007 and 2012. While his campaign rhetoric vehemently expressed Hindutva ideas, he also claimed to be governing effectively and promoting robust economic development, a message that resonated well beyond his state and gave him a credible national reputation for decisive and impactful leadership. This in turn propelled him to the position of the BJP's candidate for prime minister in 2014, and to a resounding victory in the general elections held across India that year.

Under Prime Minister Modi, the BJP has a sizeable parliamentary majority on its own that it had never enjoyed before; it is, therefore, not